



Central African Republic

The Central African Republic (CAR) is a landlocked country lying between the basins of the Chad and Congo Rivers. Politics has suffered frequent interruption by military coups.



GEOGRAPHY

Comprises a low plateau, covered by scrub or savanna. North is arid. Equatorial rainforests in the south. The Ubangi River forms the border with the Democratic Republic of the Congo.



CLIMATE

The south is equatorial; the north is hot and dry. Rain occurs all year round, with heaviest falls between July and October.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

The Baya and Banda are the largest ethnic groups, but the lingua franca is Sango, a trading creole spoken by the minorities in the south who have traditionally provided most political leaders. Less than 2% of the population live in the north. Recent rebellions by northern groups have displaced thousands of people.



THE ECONOMY

Dominated by subsistence farming. Exports include diamonds, cotton, timber, and coffee. Aid needed to support refugees. Instability and poor infrastructure hinder progress.



INSIGHT: "Emperor" Bokassa's eccentric rule from 1965 to 1979 was followed by military dictatorship until democracy was restored in 1993



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Central African Republic

DATE OF FORMATION: 1960

CAPITAL: Bangui

POPULATION: 4.42 million

TOTAL AREA: 240,534 sq. miles
(622,984 sq. km)

DENSITY: 18 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Sango, Banda, Gbaya, French*

RELIGIONS: Traditional beliefs 60%, Christian 35%, Muslim 5%

ETHNIC MIX: Baya 34%, Banda 27%, Mandjia 21%, Sara 10%, other 8%

GOVERNMENT: Presidential system

CURRENCY: CFA franc = 100 centimes